with Pakistan's catastrophic loss of the 1971 Bangladesh war, the Indian test spurred the Pakistanis to energetically pursue their own nuclear weapons program.[3] Both sides continued to develop their capabilities in the years that followed, and by the late 1980s the two countries had managed to acquire a de facto nuclear weapons capacity. From roughly 1990 forward, India and Pakistan did not actually possess nuclear weapons but could probably have produced them in short order if necessary. As the years progressed, both sides increasingly viewed each other, and were seen by outside powers, as possessing a viable nuclear weapons capability.[4] Thus South Asia's nuclear era dates back not just to the 1998 tests, but to India's and Pakistan's acquisition of an untested and undeclared nuclear capacity at the end of the previous decade. What impact did the acquisition of a de facto nuclear weapons capacity have on the strategic environment in South Asia?

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India's nuclear weapons program originated shortly after its failure to obtain a nuclear guarantee from the great powers in the aftermath of the first Chinese nuclear test at Lop Nor in 1964.[5] In the aftermath of the rebuff from the great powers, India embarked on the Subterranean Nuclear Explosions Project (SNEP).[6] The SNEP culminated in India's first nuclear test in 1974.[7] Faced with widespread international disapprobation and substantial sanctions, the country curtailed the program. Prime Minister Morarji Desai, who briefly succeeded Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, was morally opposed to nuclear weapons and it is believed that he temporarily shelved the program. With Mrs. Gandhi's return to office, the program was revived. Fearful of external pressures, however, and cognizant of the fragility of India's domestic economic circumstances, she chose not to carry out further tests.[8]

During this time Pakistan steadily pursued a clandestine nuclear weapons program. The Pakistani program had its antecedents in the aftermath of the country's catastrophic defeat in the 1971 war.[9] Prime Minister Zulfikar Ali Bhutto had decided that only nuclear